

celebrity in his writing. "The oral epic of Pabuji is very much a living tradition of the travelling storyteller," explains Kavita Singh, textile scholar at Jawaharlal Nehru University, Delhi. The *phad* depicts the exploits of the incarnate god, doomed to die for the protection of cattle. "Iconographically, it's extremely complex," she adds. "The images are organised according to a strict logic which has more in common with a roadmap than with a comic-strip." But it's more a "moral map" for the devotees, depicting, at one level, the tension between human choice and divine will and the ambivalent relationship between the lower-castes and the Rajputs, at another. As the scroll unfolds, one catches a subversive story, where ruling Rajputs are ridiculed as weaklings in the face of unlikely adversaries such as cowherds and minstrels. "The social mobility and class struggle inherent in the tale, ironically, are now being used as a political tool for the Gurjars in their caste agitation," Singh points out.

Simply, surely, we are sucked into a world in which there is a cumulative sense of the richness of little lives, and marginal histories that don't find room in textbooks: how women in the North-east wove nature—red for blood, zigzag for jungle tracks, black for night sky and cowrie shells for skulls or stars—into the mantles of merit and identity for their men; how the ancient motif of the Tree of Life appears on textiles; how women's stories on the sujni-khatwa stitching of Bihar today touch upon modern concerns—from education, work, social issues, even AIDS and communal harmony; how the Vrindavani Vastra of Assam, eulogising Vishnu's avatars vanished from the textile map; how Goan women embraced the embroidered long blouse (*bhaju*), pleated wrap-around (*pano*) and stoles, to negotiate between two cultures—Portuguese Catholic and Hindu. Tales of other textiles—khadi, Chamba ru-

mal, Pichwai of Srinathji, Buddhist Tanghka paintings, namabali—added to the repertoire.

After three days, some vital lessons were learnt: of the thousands of different textiles woven, printed, embroidered and painted across India, a significant number clearly has a story to tell; many were created by marginalised classes in remote communities and portrayed the hitherto ignored everyday trials and tribulation of underclasses; mythologies on and of textiles have historically been greater than we imagine and are continuing to create a rich variety of styles; and the narratives of the nation are not just restricted to the written word but to the many histories of its people in multifarious forms. But that, say

social scientists, also raises unique issues. "The notion of multicultural narratives is true to India," admits sociologist Dipankar Gupta, professor at Jawaharlal Nehru University. "But once the process of nation-making starts, those multiple identities get compressed within the mother narrative of the nation state and the need to be a citizen." On the sunny side, however, the "small people" are bestowed the dignity of citizenship.

Siyahi's conference certainly unravelled unbelievable stories, offered a feast for the eyes, spun magic with words, raised hopes and left several unanswered questions. One hopes to find many more mantles of myth on the nation's journey up the textile track.



Lost Message

“Textiles reveal multicultural narratives which got compressed once the nation-making process started.”
— Dipankar Gupta, sociologist



(LEFT) THE NAMABALI DESIGN;
(BELOW) VRINDAVANI VASTRA OF ASSAM



WOMEN FROM THE NORTH-EAST—THE ONLY PLACE IN THE COUNTRY WHERE ONLY WOMEN WEAVE—DISPLAY THEIR SKILLS